

CS 3563: Assignment 2 - Query Optimization Analysis

Task 4: Plan Switch Correction Experiment

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1 Introduction and Experimental Setup

In our previous analysis (Task 3), we observed that the PostgreSQL database optimizer frequently miscalculates the optimal time to switch query execution plans. It almost always switches too late (classified as DELAYED), holding onto a slower plan when a faster one is mathematically available.

The objective of this experiment in Task 4 is to correct these miscalculations. We developed a Python script to perform a binary search across the date parameters to identify the precise, mathematically optimal date where the database *should* have switched plans.

Methodology: To ensure our time measurements were perfectly accurate and unaffected by the hard drive loading data (disk-caching delays), we utilized a "cache-warming" technique. For every test, the query was executed twice, and only the stable execution time of the second run was recorded for our final dataset.

2 Experimental Results: Corrected Plan Switches

The tables below present the experimental data collected by our script. They compare the original switch dates chosen by the PostgreSQL optimizer against the true "Optimal Switch" dates identified by our binary search. We have also recorded the exact execution times (in milliseconds) for the original plan (P_i) and the alternative plan (P_j) at this newly discovered boundary.

2.1 Query 1 Results

Original Switch	Optimal Switch	$RT(P_i, q_{i'})$	$RT(P_j, q_{j'})$	$RT(P_i, q_{j'})$	$RT(P_j, q_{i'})$
1992-01-10 to 11	1992-01-16 to 17	37.036	39.570	39.171	39.814
1992-08-21 to 22	1992-05-27 to 28	4148.308	12870.647	14273.831	11843.291

2.2 Query 2 Results

Original Switch	Optimal Switch	$RT(P_i, q_{i'})$	$RT(P_j, q_{j'})$	$RT(P_i, q_{j'})$	$RT(P_j, q_{i'})$
1993-03-11 to 12	1992-02-10 to 11	381.217	432.338	438.406	424.586
1993-04-28 to 29	1993-03-24 to 25	16145.112	16126.410	16259.974	16054.867
1996-11-22 to 23	1993-07-09 to 10	14157.408	12386.650	14161.482	13005.950

2.3 Query 3 Results

Original Switch	Optimal Switch	$RT(P_i, q_{i'})$	$RT(P_j, q_{j'})$	$RT(P_i, q_{j'})$	$RT(P_j, q_{i'})$
1992-02-28 to 29	1992-01-12 to 13	169.791	181.295	185.841	163.318
1993-04-06 to 07	1992-03-14 to 15	431.426	424.843	593.880	656.088
1998-08-28 to 29	1998-08-09 to 10	15237.175	15335.284	15159.911	15707.193
1998-09-19 to 20	1998-09-01 to 02	11537.624	11489.822	11465.890	11478.032
1998-11-30 to 01	1998-11-23 to 24	42.343	35.262	36.175	53.019

3 Experimental Observations and Issues Faced

To guarantee the accuracy of our experiment, our script performed a strict mathematical verification at the end of each binary search. It tested the execution times at the new boundary to see if Plan P_i was strictly faster on the first day, and if Plan P_j successfully took the lead on the second day.

For several switches (such as Query 2 Switch 1 and Query 3 Switch 5), the script successfully printed a "CORRECT" validation. This proves that our binary search successfully isolated the exact, perfect day where the two plans flipped in performance.

However, during testing, we faced a few minor issues where the math did not cleanly flip at the boundary. Investigating the raw execution times revealed two practical reasons for this behavior in a real database environment.

3.1 Issue 1: Hitting the Safe Search Boundaries

For switches that were extremely DELAYED (such as Query 2 Switch 3), we found that the new plan (P_j) was so much faster than the old plan (P_i) that it was beating it by several full seconds.

To keep the experiment safe and accurate, we gave our binary search a strict time window. We did not want the script to search so far backward in time that it accidentally crashed into a completely different plan switch from an earlier year. Because P_j was so vastly superior, the true optimal date was actually outside our allowed safe search area. The script simply kept searching backward until it hit the boundary wall we set for it, and then it stopped. While this prevented a perfect mathematical flip, this behavior undeniably proves that the optimizer waited far too long to switch to the better plan.

3.2 Issue 2: Tiny Time Differences and System Noise

For some boundaries (such as Query 1 Switch 1 and Query 3 Switch 4), the script found a crossover point, but the difference in execution time between the two plans was incredibly small—sometimes less than 10 milliseconds.

When two plans are running that closely in speed, normal background noise on the computer can cause random, tiny delays. Because the plans are practically tied in performance, this random system noise makes it impossible to get a "perfect" mathematical flip on a specific day. The database environment is not a perfect vacuum. Even though these boundaries did not pass the strict math check, the dates found still accurately represent the region where the two plans become equally efficient.

4 Conclusion

After reviewing all the data collected during this experiment, our conclusion is very clear: the PostgreSQL optimizer is highly conservative and stubborn.

The overwhelming majority of the plan switches were severely DELAYED. As the amount of data in the database grows, methods like Sequential Scans and Hash Joins become much faster and more efficient. However, the optimizer consistently underestimates their speed. Instead, it chooses to stick with its older, familiar methods (like Index Scans and Nested Loops) for weeks or months longer than it mathematically should.